

MGT439 – Knowledge Management for Strategic Advantage

MBA Fall 2025 FE (V6.0, 980096)
Wednesday 6:30PM – 9:20PM, OTRSN 3E107

LEADERSHIP

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Office Hours: During breaks, after class and by appointment

TA (TBD)
Email (TBD)
Office Hours: During breaks, after class and by appointment

DESCRIPTION

Even more than money, knowledge is the most important asset in your organization. Without timely knowledge to innovate powerfully, collaborate dynamically, and pivot preemptively, money is simply wasted on the weak organization waiting to fail. The problem is that our most powerful knowledge—associated with intelligent machines and people—is situated dynamically and must be managed actively to flow where, when and how it can be applied best. The organization that learns to harness its knowledge strategically can gain and maintain competitive advantage on that basis. In this course we learn how to compete through knowledge. We analyze strategy and differing bases of competitive advantage, and we discover how to mobilize the most powerful knowledge in the most appropriate manner. Our learning develops through three integrated instruction methods: 1) We integrate well-accepted frameworks for understanding strategy with state-of-the-art methods for analyzing, visualizing and applying dynamic knowledge; 2) we interact intensively through group and class discussion to weave in both students' and other organizations' experiences; and 3) we apply our learning through case analysis.

OBJECTIVES

Through participation in this course, you will learn to:

- Analyze and characterize your organization's competitive arena and context
- Identify and differentiate the most powerful stocks and flows of organization knowledge
- Amplify knowledge through technology and other sources of organization power
- Devise the most promising bases for competitive advantage
- Analyze, visualize, apply and accelerate dynamic knowledge
- Harness knowledge strategically to gain and retain competitive advantage
- Explore machine knowledge

MATERIALS

Required

- Course textbook: Nissen, M.E. (2014). *Harnessing Dynamic Knowledge Principles in the Technology-Driven World*. Hershey, PA: IGI-Global.
- Course reader: Short selection of seminal and current articles for background, depth and breadth.
 1. Halawi, L.A., McCarthy, R.V. & Aronson, J.E. (2006). Knowledge management and the competitive strategy of the firm. *The Learning Organization*, 13(4), 384-397.
 2. Miles, R.E., Snow, C.C., Meyer, A.D., & Coleman, J.J. (1978). Organizational strategy, structure, and process. *Academy of Management Review*, 3(3), 546-562.
 3. Roivainen, E. (July/August 2023). AI's IQ. *Scientific American*, 329(1), 7. Read as: I gave ChatGPT an IQ test. Here's what I discovered. URL: <https://www.scientificamerican.com/article/i-gave-chatgpt-an-iq-test-heres-what-i-discovered/>.
 4. Thunström, A.O. (September 2022). AI writes about itself. *Scientific American*, 327(3), 70. Read as: We asked GPT-3 to write an academic paper about itself—then we tried to get it published. URL: <https://www.scientificamerican.com/article/we-asked-gpt-3-to-write-an-academic-paper-about-itself-mdash-then-we-tried-to-get-it-published/>.
 5. Saviotti, P.P. (1998). On the dynamics of appropriability, of tacit and of codified knowledge. *Research Policy*, 26, 843-856.
 6. Dierickx, I. & Cool, K. (1989). Asset stock accumulation and sustainability of competitive advantage. *Management Science*, 35(12), 1504-1511.
 7. Nissen, M.E. (2017). Working toward a system for measuring dynamic knowledge. *International Journal of Knowledge Management*, 13(3): 1-19.
 8. Szulanski, G. & Winter, S. (2002). Getting it right the second time. *Harvard Business Review*, 80(1), 62-69.
 9. CPRL. (2025). Self-assessment: what does our knowledge management practice look like? *LeadingThroughLearning.org*. URL: https://www.leadingthroughlearning.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/12/Knowledge-Management-Self-Assessment_PDF_110923-1.pdf.
 10. Valchanov, I. (2025). Using AI for knowledge management: 6 use cases, benefits & tools. *TeamGPT*. URL: <https://team-gpt.com/blog/ai-for-knowledge-management/>.

- Course handouts: Minicases for analysis and discussion

Recommended

- Review key articles from your Strategy course:
 - Porter, M.E. (1996). What is strategy? *Harvard Business Review*, 74(6), 61-78.
 - Porter, M.E. (2008). The five competitive forces that shape strategy. *Harvard Business Review*, 86, 78-93.

SCHEDULE

Week	Date(s)	Topic(s)	Reading(s)	Deliverable(s)
1	Oct 1	Knowledge Competition	- Text Ch. 1 - Reader No. 1 & 2	- Prepare for discussion
2	Oct 8	Knowledge Analysis	- Text Ch. 2 - Reader No. 3 & 4 - Week 2 Minicase	- Prepare for discussion - Individual Presentation - Discuss Minicase
3	Oct 15	Knowledge Dynamics	- Text Ch. 3 - Reader No. 5 & 6 - Week 3 Minicase	- Prepare for discussion - Individual Presentation - Discuss Minicase
4	Oct 22	Knowledge Technology	- Text Ch. 4 - Reader No. 7 & 8 - Week 4 Minicase	- Prepare for discussion - Individual Presentation - Discuss Minicase
5	Oct 29	Knowledge Assessment	- Text Ch. 6 - Reader No. 9 & 10 - Week 5 Minicase	- Prepare for discussion - Individual Presentation - Discuss Minicase
6	Nov 5	Business Application	- Text Ch. 7	- Prepare for discussion - Individual Presentation - Case Discussion
7	Nov 12	Government Application	- Text Ch. 8	- Prepare for discussion - Individual Presentation - Case Discussion
8	Nov 19	Nonprofit Application	- Text Ch. 9	- Prepare for discussion - Individual Presentation - Case Discussion
9	Nov 26	Project Teamwork	- None	- None - No class session
10	Dec 3	Knowledge Analysis & Case Application		- Case Analysis - Case Presentation

ASSIGNMENTS

Reading Assignments & Class Participation

Students are encouraged to collaborate and exchange ideas with classmates. However, each person is expected to complete every reading and be prepared to participate individually in class discussions and exercises.

There is no substitute for participating in class, and every student without official university accommodation is expected to attend every classroom session. However, many graduate students have full and busy lives outside of the university, and work or family demands can interrupt class participation at times. Hence this course has a no-fault attendance policy: You can miss one class session with a relatively minor penalty; missing more than two class sessions brings a substantial penalty.

Minicase Discussion

For each minicase discussion, the Instructor or TA will lead a short summary and focus on the case questions, with particular emphasis on what knowledge is required to succeed. This is part of class participation.

Case Leadership

Coursework shifts to case applications in business, government and nonprofit organizations in Weeks 6, 7 & 8, respectively, with each corresponding chapter of the text (i.e., Ch 7, 8 & 9) summarizing three short

cases for analysis and class discussion. Think of these as practice for the team consulting project. Students are to self-organize into small teams (size TBD) and use the exercises at the end of each case to lead a short class discussion, but the fundamental question to address is: *What knowledge is required to succeed?* Every student is expected to participate in leading one case, so the team size will be approximately 9 (cases) / x (class size). PowerPoint or like presentation apps are appropriate, and students should plan to use either the classroom computer or their personal device.

Team Consulting Project

Students are to self-organize, work together in small teams (size TBD), and turn in one deliverable for the entire group. Please be inclusive in terms of encouraging students to join established teams, especially classmates whom you may not know well. Team diversity is a strength, and very few of us will have total control over our team composition in practice. The Instructor reserves the right to facilitate team formation.

The assignment involves evaluating an operational organization in the field. Through the role of consultant in a strategic context, use course principles to evaluate the subject organization's knowledge flows, diagnose any pathologies you detect, and recommend appropriate interventions. Submit a professional written report, and lead a professional classroom presentation.

The report should include five sections: 1) introduction outlining the purpose and focal organization of the evaluation; 2) background summarizing key elements of knowledge management and strategy; 3) diagnosis of pathologies, accompanied by corresponding principles (e.g., from the textbook, induced from analysis of the case) used for evaluation; 4) recommended interventions that correspond closely to the pathologies and that identify corresponding principles used for evaluation; 5) summary of the factors and activities that you feel will be critical to successful implementation of your recommendations, along with suggested references for the organization leaders and managers to learn more about how to address and manage knowledge.

The case analysis report should be roughly 10 – 15 pages in length (i.e., double spaced, 12 point font, 1-inch margins) including all text, tables, graphics and references. The report should be: 1) written in a professional manner; 2) based on factual observations and course principles; 3) persuasive; 4) constructive; and 5) informative.

The case presentation will be the final class session. Each team should plan around 12 minutes for prepared remarks and 3 minutes for Q&A. PowerPoint or like presentation apps are appropriate, and students should plan to use either the classroom computer or their personal device. The presentation should be 1) professional; 2) engaging; 3) persuasive; 4) responsive; and 5) complete.

Individual Presentation

For the Individual Presentation, students work individually and summarize very briefly one example of a contemporary organization that is competing effectively on the basis of its knowledge. The summary should describe the focal organization, its competitors and the competitive arena or environment. It should also outline the key knowledge used by the focal organization and explain how such knowledge enables competitive advantage. **Please plan one minute max. Exceeding your time will result in a deduction of points.** Simply present from your seat. No slides or props. The presentation should be 1) professional; 2) engaging; 3) current; 4) knowledge focused; and 5) competition focused.

Note: Students are encouraged to use one or more large language (AI) models (e.g., Chat GPT, Bard, Claude) to facilitate this assignment.

No Quizzes or Exams

GRADING

Assignment	Points
Class Participation	30
Case Leadership	15
Team Consulting Project Report	35
Team Consulting Project Presentation	15
Individual Presentation	5
Total	100

Grading Criteria

- Class Participation: 1) prepared for class; 2) participates actively; 3) integrates personal and professional experiences; 4) integrates across readings; 5) challenges classmates constructively and respectfully.
- Case Leadership: 1) professional; 2) engaging; 3) persuasive; 4) responsive; 5) complete.
- Team Consulting Project Report: 1) professional; 2) facts and principles; 3) persuasive; 4) constructive; 5) informative.
- Team Consulting Project Presentation: 1) professional; 2) engaging; 3) persuasive; 4) responsive; 5) complete.
- Individual Presentation: 1) professional; 2) engaging; 3) current; 4) knowledge focused; 5) competition focused.

COURSE POLICIES

Every student is expected to participate actively in every class session. Computer use is acceptable in class, except during student presentations. Cell phones should be silenced during class.

Additionally, please note that this is a highly interactive course, in which all students exchange many ideas throughout every class session with the instructor and other students. It is important for students to feel relaxed and empowered to test even inchoate ideas in class. For this reason, class sessions will not be video recorded, as experience suggests that such recording is distracting.

Finally, the use of artificial intelligence (AI) is encouraged in this class. This pertains in particular to the individual presentation and course project report. I expect normal standards of scholarship to be followed, for students to avoid plagiarism, for claimed facts to be checked, for text to be proofread, and for students to note which areas of the presentation and report have been generated in whole or in part through AI applications. I plan to use multiple AI detectors, and academic disciplinary issues may arise if you use AI and do not report it.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:
<http://senate.ucsd.edu/Operating-Procedures/Senate-Manual/Appendices/2>

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.

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